

Build a clear prompt → Explore → Iterative vs single → Refine → PDF template → Verify output

Build a clear prompt

Activity · Prompting techniques · ~15 min

BEFORE YOU START

- You're signed in to the FASTR platform with the AI Assistant available
- You have a real workshop task in mind that you'd normally do (a chart, a summary, a slide for a meeting)

WHY IT MATTERS

A clear prompt produces a useful answer; a vague prompt produces a generic one. The difference is **what you put in** — most of the value comes from a 30-second pre-flight before you type.

Six dimensions before you type

Pick a task you do regularly. Before writing your prompt, check it covers these six dimensions.

1. Clear objective. Is the task explicit (*interpret, summarise, compare, draft slides*) and the use case named (*performance review, donor update, training*)?

2. Target audience. Who's it for? At what technical level?

3. Geography, period, scope. National or subnational? Time period? Priority indicators or services?

4. Interpretation guidance. Should the AI describe, compare, or identify disruptions? Description only, or include implications?

5. Output format. Bullets or narrative? Slide-ready or prose? Length limit?

6. Guardrails. Tell the AI to stick to the data shown and flag uncertainties or data-quality issues.

Now write your prompt

Use the six dimensions above to write a prompt that names **objective**, **audience**, **scope**, **interpretation guidance**, **format**, and **guardrails**. One paragraph is fine.

Your prompt:

The golden rule

Before you press Enter, ask yourself: *"Is what I expect back obvious?"* If not, add one more detail.

Refining is normal too. You don't have to get the prompt right in one go — you can keep talking to the AI to narrow it down. The six dimensions above just give you a stronger first message.

What's next

Move on to **Explore with the AI Assistant** to try this prompt against the platform and learn how small changes to a prompt change the output.